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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Beyond Economics: Consensus-Building as a Cultural Practice in East Asia

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Research Topic: International Relations and East Asian Studies in Social Sciences

Introduction

Once I saw people from different religious backgrounds participating in a sub-forum at the Boao Forum for Asia. Then this made me curious about why so many religious figures were present at such a platform mainly discuses with economic and political. I later learned that they were taking part in discussions about religious harmony and mutual learning among civilizations. After attending ， I began to search for more information and came across the classical secularization thesis [1] in Western modernization theory. Simply put, it suggests that religion gradually withdraws from public decision-making. However, the thesis in many parts of Asia doesn't seem to fit this model at all . Religion, traditional culture, and economic development still intersect in some situations. And this led me to think further about consensus-building.

I also found that many entrepreneurs at the forum interacted more like friends than formal participants. Later, I interviewed a famous business researcher about this issue. In his view, trust mechanisms in East Asia can play a greater role than institutional mechanisms. He compared this to the degree of steak that coked: trust also matters in other regions, but if it's role is five out of ten there , it may be eight or nine out of ten in East Asia.

Research Problem

Research on East Asian cooperation often focuses on economic interdependence, political interests and formal institutions. These factors are important,but they leave one practical question unanswered: how do actors with different preferences reach terms that they can all accept? In many regional environments, this is achieved through repeated interaction. Participants explain their goals, exchange information, revise their positions, and make sure that no one thinks there is an unacceptable part. ASEAN offers a clear example of the importance of this process: Article 20 of the ASEAN Charter states that decision-making shall be based on consultation and consensus [2].

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The proposal regarded consensus building as a cultural practice, not just a purpose. It studies whether relationships, repeated interactions, and common expectations shape the way actors are coordinated.

Existing game-theoretic research on Asian international relations has used formal analysis to examine strategic interaction, institutional formation, and cooperation and conflict. Motoshi Suzuki and Akira Okada's edited volume Games of cooperation and conflict in Asia [3] combines game-theoretic analysis with accounts of Asian international relations. It shows how states create, modify, or dismantle institutions through conflict and cooperation.

My project focusses on building consensus itself, as a dynamic process that connects calculative trust and relational trust. It understands the construction of the East Asian consensus as a multi-agent dynamic system, linking repeated interaction, adjustment, changing expectations, trust formation and relatively stable cooperation.

Existing Literature

Relevant research shows that regional cooperation not only relies on material interests, but also involves identity and norms. Acharya describes institutional construction in the Asia-Pacific area as a process related to identity formation. His later work also studied how ASEAN norms were developed and challenged [4], [5]. The ASEAN Charter gives consultation and consensus a formal role in decision-making [2]. Other studies show that political, economic and cultural factors are closely related in regional cooperation [6]. Recent research explains how ASEAN presidents combine different positions under consensus rules. It also shows how shared meaning, flexibility and social relations support regional cooperation centred on ASEAN [7], [8]. These studies show the connection between formal procedures and the actual practices of cooperation.

In this study, Eisenstadt's idea of multiple modernity helped me think about whether the construction consensus in East Asia is influenced by its own cultural and historical background [9]. Fei Xiaotong's description of relationship-based social life and the Confucian idea of harmony and non-unification helped me explore how actors can harmoniously influence interaction through relationships and social obligations without eliminating differences [10], [11]. Research on China negotiations warns that all actors should not be given the same fixed cultural style [12]. Recent multicultural studies also suggest that relationship behaviour changes through interaction, not a permanent national characteristic [13].

I use early research to explain how interaction leads to consensus. Repeated interaction gives actors more opportunities to respond to each other and provides conditions for mutual response [14] ， When actors are uncertain about each other's intentions, trust affects how they understand each other's behaviour [15]. Aumann's model also helped me understand the concept of common knowledge [16]. I use this model to analyse how the ideas in the actor's own cognition become common cognition through interaction. Changes in trust will also change the form and degree of cooperation but didn’t mean that the cooperation will end. [17], [18].

Existing scholarship covers institutions, cultural and relational logics, trust, bargaining, and cooperation. There is still a gap in explaining how these elements work together at the level of the consensus-building process.

Research Questions

1. How is consensus-building constructed through interactions among political, economic, cultural, and religious actors in East Asia, and what does this show about East Asian approaches to cooperation beyond economic interests?
2. What cultural and civilizational logics behind consensus-building in East Asia, and to what extent does this practice reflect deeper civilizational traditions rooted in the region?
3. To what extent can trust that develops through consensus-building sustain cooperation beyond quantifiable economic assessments and formal policy or institutional support?

Methodology

The methodology of this study is a qualitative research approach.

Literature-based theoretical and interpretive analysis. Fei Xiaotong’s relational social framework, harmony without uniformity, multiple modernities, ASEAN-consensus scholarship, and contemporary relational research provide interpretive resources for the study [2], [4], [5], [7], [8], [9], [10], [11], [12], [13]. Their implications will be examined through cases and interviews. This study will explore the practice of cultural and civilised traditions by actors.

Case studies compare and process-oriented analysis. ASEAN consensus practices and the Boao Forum for Asia provide rich evidence cases within the broader East Asian inquiry, but don't limit the study's scope to these two settings. The common unit of analysis is an episode that moves from disagreement through interaction and adjustment toward a workable agreement. This allows similar mechanisms to be compared across different institutional settings and groups of actors.

Publicly available materials from 2015 to 2025，including institutional statements, reports, and published records of dialogue，These materials will help me use specific cases to analyse how the consensus is stable after repeated interaction and adjustment. When the actor's original position changes after expressing, responding, exchanging information and adjusting, and reaching an acceptable area for everyone, a consensus is formed. When the consensus is formed, whether the cooperation will continue also requires the later participation and working relationship between the actors who study these materials, and the common expectation of change. Then compare the decline in trust and continuous cooperation as negative cases, so as to study whether trust is more important than economic incentives and rules.

Semi-structured interviews. I plan to purposefully select 15-20 people with relevant experience for voluntary interviews, such as entrepreneurs, scholars, and people who have worked in the government or public sector, to understand how trust is formed and whether cooperation can continue when economic interests are unclear or lack formal policy and institutional support. And I will compare with public information to find points of mutual support and contradiction.

Analytic Framework

I regard different participants as actors in a dynamic system. They have different interests but will influence each other. By observing the changes in interaction, I judge whether their expectations and trust in each other have changed and analyse how the factors in the existing concept affect the construction of consensus, while culture is a factor that affects how the interaction forms consensus.

Common interests can be expressed by feasible-set logic. Assuming that each actor has a plan that can be accepted, to reach a consensus, it means that the final intersection of all schemes cannot be an empty set. However, if the final intersection is empty, everyone will change the constraints to make the intersection not empty as much as possible. It can be regarded as the variable change in the consensus-building formula is itself a political behaviour in the real world.

When reading each case, I will use following ideas to interpret the evidence.Using Nash bargaining to identify what each actor wants, what limits its choices, what it can do if no agreement is reached, and what it may gain from agreement [19]. Bhaumik et al. show how different objectives and outside options can be organized in a political-economy analysis [20].

I will use Bayesian updating to follow how an actor's view of another changes after observing commitments, concessions, credible communication, or defection [15]. After the participants' judgement of each other changes, whether this change is understood and confirmed by other participants through public expression or actual action. Aumann's result helps understand how private beliefs become beliefs that are common known [16].

I use the concept of fixed points as a metaphor, which can be seen as that each actor constantly makes demands, responds to requests, adjusts positions, exchanges information, makes concessions, seeks common interests, and avoids unacceptable results until no participant has enough reason to unilaterally change his position. Fixed-point reasoning is related to balanced analysis [21], but I will not test whether any situation satisfies the mathematical theorem.

In this study, calculative trust means that the actor expects cooperation because predictable behaviour, credible promises or expected benefits make it reasonable. Relational trust comes from past conduct, recognition, reciprocity, lasting relationships, obligations, and shared expectations [22]. Some research in international relations treats trust and calculation as different ways of anticipating behaviour [18].I will explore how how consensus-building connects calculative and relational trust. Participants may initially weigh mainly based on interest, predictability and commitment to generate calculative trust. In the construction of consensus, repeated interaction and adjustment further generate or strengthen relational trust, which supports follow-up cooperation.

As for cultural factors，I will look at whether concern for harmony, relational norms, face, reciprocity, or context-specific obligations affects how actors share information, handle disagreement, make compromises, build trust, or maintain relationships [10], [11], [12], [13]. I will judge the importance of each factor by looking at what the actors say and do in each case.

I will use the following categories to explain the dynamism of building consensus：

C = f(I, O, M, R | N),

C：consensus-building
I：interdependence
O：overlapping interests
M：mutual vulnerability
R：repeated interaction
N：normative and cultural framework.

I will bring documents, case plots and interviews into the code to analyse this dynamic process, in which N does not directly determine C, but affects how other variables are transformed into consensus-building. The expression is a coded heuristic, not a deterministic equation.

Research Topic and Significance

The study focuses on consensus-building itself as a dynamic process, and is further connected to calculative and relational trust, also tries to establish a theoretical framework that regards East Asian consensus construction as a multi-agent dynamic system. In practice, the findings may provide insight into how trust developed through consensus-building can support continued cooperation beyond clear economic calculations and formal policy or institutional.

Post-Program Plan

After the program, I will finish the proposal into a complete research paper. Then I plan to collect more case studies and conduct extensive interviews with participants from the political, economic and business fields. I also plan to share research results through youth entrepreneurship programs, academic conferences, research groups, international business conferences, and regional or international forums.

On the one hand,I hope to help young people who participate in international entrepreneurship or cooperation understand that there are also factors that affect the possibility of cooperation in addition to economy and system. If these factors that are hard to see can be explained, it may be easier for young people without business experience to understand and participate in such cooperation.

On the other hand, with experienced entrepreneurs and business leaders will emphasize that trust, familiar relationships and harmony-oriented attention should complement rather than replace transparent standards, formal institutions and economic assessments.

In the long term, I hope that this research will be used as a publication and become the basis for further dialogue between young researchers and people in different fields interested in East Asian cooperation.

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